In Influencers We Trust? A Model of Trust Transfer in Social Media Influencer Marketing

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Abstract This study is designed to investigate whether customers' trust in social media influencers translates to them trusting the brands endorsed by said influencers. It, additionally, explores the role of brand liking and ad enjoyment in this model of trust transfer. Data was collected from 354 respondents who were asked to complete online survey questions after watching video adverts featuring social media influencers endorsing different brands. The dataset was then analyzed using PLS-SEM techniques. Based on the analysis, influencer trust was found to positively affect brand trust, brand liking, and ad enjoyment. Brand liking was also found to positively affect customers' brand trust. However, there was no support of ad enjoyment's effect on customers' brand trust. The results lend support to the theory of trust transfer in the context of social media influencer marketing. The findings from this study are useful for social media influencers, as they highlight the importance of nurturing a trusting relationship between them and their audience. This trust is expected to transfer to customers' trusting in and liking of endorsed brands and therefore contribute to the success of the social media influencer business model. This study adds insights to the still growing research on social media influencer marketing, specifically shedding light on the effects of customers' trust in influencers, a much-discussed area of late.

Keywords Social media marketing · Trust transfer · Social media influencers

1 Introduction

As the internet and social media technologies grew dramatically in recent years, a new type of customer has emerged. One that is empowered by the interactive capabilities of the internet to speak up and share their opinions and views on everything from politics to brands (Almahdi, 2021; Turban et al., 2016). As these technological advancements democratized communication (Kietzmann et al., 2011), they have also

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given way to new entrepreneurial opportunities and contributed to the creation of the phenomenon that is known as the social media influencer (SMI) (Wilkinson, 2019).

1.1 Social Media Influencers

According to Hearn and Schoenhoff (Hearn & Schoenhoff, 2016), a social media influencer is an individual who "works to generate a form of "celebrity" capital by cultivating as much attention as possible and crafting an authentic "personal brand" via social networks, which can subsequently be used by companies and advertisers for consumer outreach" (p. 194). SMIs facilitate a variety of social media platforms (including but not limited to YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, and TikTok) to endorse products and brands to their social following, in return for receiving some sort of reward from the endorsed party (Freberg et al., 2011; Liljander et al., 2015). Rewards can vary from getting exposure by the endorsed party to receiving sample products, gift cards, or monetary compensation (Liljander et al., 2015). By employing social media influencers, marketers aim to revamp the way that they connect with their end consumers and grow their relationship with them by associating with people who are of interest to them (Glucksman, 2017) and who are already trusted by them (Kim & Kim, 2021).

Examples of social media influencers include Ryan Kaji, a nine-year-old American YouTuber, who unboxes toys on video to his 30.5 million subscribers in return for financial compensation by toy brands, and Khaby Lame, a Senegalese-Italian TikTok sensation with more than 117 million followers, who promotes brands such as Boss and Dream 11 through his social channels. Some influencers even advertise their own brands through social media. For example, when Kylie Jenner, a beauty and lifestyle influencer with 277 million Instagram followers, released her own brand's lip gloss kit for sale in 2015, it got sold out in less than a minute (Holmes, 2015).

Social media influencers have been compared to traditional celebrities in prior research (Glucksman, 2017), as both influencers and traditional celebrities often endorse products and brands in exchange for compensation. In a research paper contrasting the two, Schouten and colleagues (Schouten et al., 2020) found that customers trust social media influencers more than they do traditional celebrities, as they find the first more similar to them as everyday people than the latter. The customers are, therefore, more influenced by influencer- (rather than traditional celebrity-) advertising (Schouten et al., 2020). Similarly, Djafarova and Rushworth (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017) found that non-traditional celebrities, such as vloggers, bloggers, YouTubers and 'Instafamous' celebrities are more influential, more relatable, and more trustworthy than traditional celebrities.

Marketers are increasingly realizing the importance of this marketing method and dedicating a growing part of their budgets to it (Influencer Marketig Hub, 2021). Indeed, influencer marketing has reached a reported worth of $13.8 billion globally in 2021 (Influencer Marketig Hub, 2021). Still, influencer marketing is a nascent research area (Glucksman, 2017; Kim & Kim, 2021), riddled with questions about its contribution to return on investment (ROI), its role in influencing customer buying decisions and attitudes (Wynne Lockhart, 2021), and the nuances of customer trust in SMIs (Kim & Kim, 2021). The question about customer trust in SMIs is gaining more urgency as customers' views toward this marketing method have recently been clouded with suspicion and skepticism (Kim & Kim, 2021). This can be attributed to customers' increasing awareness of manipulative marketing practices, knowledge about well-publicized transgressions by some social media influencers, and eventually the rise in influencer fatigue and cancel culture (Field, 2021; Open Influence, 2020; Shaw, 2019; Singh et al., 2020).

1.2 Trust and Social Media Influencers

The concept of trust has always come to the forefront when researching influencers in prior research, as it can be regarded as the backbone of this business model (Freberg et al., 2011; Friedman et al., 1978; Jin et al., 2021; Kim & Kim, 2021; Liljander et al., 2015; Lim et al., 2017; Pop, 2021). Indeed, customers view the recommendations they receive from social media influencers in the same light they view the recommendations they receive from friends and family, which is more trustworthy and credible than the advertisers' messages (Liljander et al., 2015; Osatuyi & Turel, 2019). Trust is especially important in digital marketing environments, because of their highly uncertain nature and lack of a tangibility (Chen et al., 2019).

Mayer and Colleagues (Mayer et al., 1995) define trust as "the willingness of a party to be vulnerable to the actions of another party based on the expectation that the other will perform a particular action important to the trustor, irrespective of the ability to monitor or control that other party" (p. 712). Humans use trust as a way to navigate the overwhelming complexities of their social environments and predict other people's future behaviors toward them (Gefen & Straub, 2004).

Ohanian (1990) is one of the earlier researchers to shed light on the vital role of influencer trustworthiness in changing customer attitudes. Along the same lines, Djafarova and Rushworth (2017) cite the importance of source credibility, including their trustworthiness, to explain the effect of Instagram influencers on the purchase decisions of young females. Similarly, Freberg and colleagues (2011) link the trustworthiness of social media influencers to customer behavioral intentions, while Chatzigeorgiou (2017) outlines number of followers and attractive personality as antecedent to trust in social media influencers. Additionally, while investigating the concept of influencer marketing, Lou and Yuan (2019) introduce a model of social media influencer value. They position consumer's trust in social media influencers as a main factor of said model, as they link it to important outcome variables such as brand awareness and purchase intentions (Lou & Yuan, 2019).

Still, there is more to learn about the mechanisms, magnitude, and marketing-related outcomes of trust in social media influencers (Chatzigeorgiou, 2017; Freberg et al., 2011; Liljander et al., 2015). This is especially important as the consumers of today are more informed about marketing practices than they ever were and hence are getting more skeptical about marketing techniques such as product placement and influencer marketing (Liljander et al., 2015; Statista., 2018). Moreover, the authenticity and trustworthiness of social media influencers has also come into hot debate in recent years (Mannheim, 2021; Singh et al., 2020; Watson, 2019), and the Fyre Festival controversy brings to light the public's disillusion with social media influencers. In the 2017 incident, about 400 world-famous social media influencers were enlisted to promote a huge new music festival, called the Fyre Festival. This new festival was promised by those influencers to be a luxurious, exclusive affair set in a private island in the Caribbean. Consequently, tickets to the event were sold out in 48 h (Shaw, 2019). However, the festival eventually turned out to be a scam and hundreds of attendees ended up stranded on an island with no food, no accommodation, and no festival in sight. Although the doomed festival's organizer ended up in prison, the public started wondering whether influencers can be held responsible to what they promote, whether they can even be trusted anymore (Smith & Fyre, 2019), and if they were trusted, whether this trust still transfers to products and brands they promote.

2 Conceptual Model and Hypothesis Justification

A lot of questions about the trustworthiness of social media influencers and the effectiveness of this mode of marketing comes to light (Mannheim, 2021; Singh et al., 2020; Watson, 2019). Do customers still trust influencers? Is influencer marketing still a successful way of transferring goodwill from influencer to brand? Does liking the brand play a part into this transfer of trust? What about enjoying the content made by the influencer as a means of advertising? These are some questions that we are aiming to answer through the study's model (Fig. 1). The items in the model

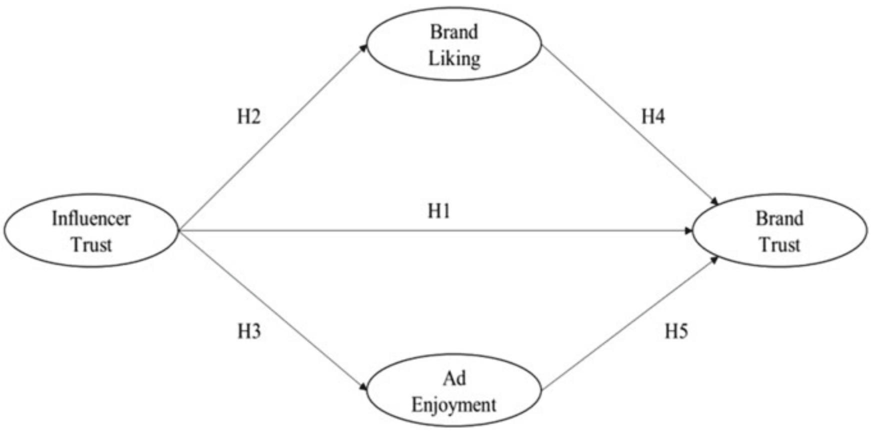

Fig. 1 Conceptual model

were produced based on focus groups of young-adult social media users who were questioned about possible factors that affect their responses to influencer marketing on social media.

To better understand the effectiveness of trusting a social media influencer and if it translates to trusting a brand, the theory of trust transfer is considered in this research. This theory manifests when an audience start trusting a specific party (i.e., a person, brand, or product) because it has been associated with or endorsed by a party that they already trust (Hu et al., 2019; Stewart, 2003). Smith (2004) explains the theory in terms of a transfer of meaning, highlighting that trust can transfer between an endorser to the endorsed product or even between two brands through co-branding. It was also found that trust can transfer from a seller to the product they are selling (Zhao et al., 2019). Along the same lines, it is expected that the theory of trust transfer applies to the relationship between the social media influencer and the brand or product they are endorsing. Therefore, we hypothesize that:

H1: Customers' trust in SMIs positively affects their trust in the brands they endorse.

Customers' trust in a social media influencer is similarly expected to influence the customers' brand liking, or the customers' positive attitude toward a brand based on their perception of its care about them (Boutie, 1994). Indeed, based on an understanding of the signaling theory, it can surmised that trust in a recommender influences customers' attitudes toward the product they are recommending, especially when there is a lack of information available about it (Chen et al., 2019). Indeed, Chen and colleagues explain that trusted recommenders (i.e. influencers) use informational cues to signal trustworthiness and differentiate the products that they are endorsing from others, and consequently influence the buyers' feelings and behaviors toward the endorsed products (Chen et al., 2019).This relationship can be further explained through the social learning theory, which indicates that people tend to pick up on certain behaviors by noting and then following the expected successful behaviors of influential others (Bandura, 1971; Glucksman, 2017). Therefore, if a social media influencer is behaving positively toward a brand by recommending it to their followers, those followers could end up behaving positively toward the brand and liking it. Therefore, we hypothesize that:

H2: Customers' trust in SMIs positively affects their liking of the brands they endorse.

Along the lines of discussing the effects of influencer trust is a suggestion in prior research that the more credible the communicator is, the more interesting their message will be perceived by an audience (Nurhandayani et al., 2019). Indeed, research findings have highlighted that when a consumer trusts a party (i.e., the influencer in this situation), it means that they believe that this party will take their best interest in mind, and this can free the consumer from concern and allow them to pay attention to and enjoy what this party is offering (i.e., the advert) (McKnight et al., 2002). Moreover, Wu and Chang (2005) have found that in the context of online interactions, predictability is connected to enjoyment. Since predictability is an important facet of trust as discussed earlier (Gefen & Straub, 2004), we hypothesize that:

H3: Customers' trust in SMIs positively affects their enjoyment of the adverts they make to endorse brands.

As discussed earlier, a connection between liking and trust exists, where trust of an influencer leads to brand liking. But does liking a brand lead to trusting it? Nicholson et al., (2001) explain that liking, a favorable emotional connection, grows feeling of trusts in consumers, because "more favorable motives are assigned to liked people" (p. 5). Indeed, likability is comprised by a number of characteristics, including sincerity, thoughtfulness and consideration, which are all connected to trust in the literature (Lau & Lee, 1999). Doney and Cannon (1997) explain the significant relationship they found between liking and trust from the perspective of the prediction process. Indeed, if a person likes someone, they will be more likely to trust their own predictions about the way that this person will behave in the future (Doney & Cannon, 1997). Applied to the context of this study, liking a certain brand means that you trust that the people behind it will treat you well by selling you products and services that are in your best interest. Therefore, we hypothesize that:

H4: Customers' liking of a brand positively affects their trust in it.

When discussing the connection between enjoyment and trust, Hampton-Sosa and Koufaris (2005) suggest that perceived enjoyment of a communication channel can influence customers' trust in the party that owns it through the mediating role of appeal. This shows that enjoyment of an online marketing channel (in our research context, the influencer's ad) can transfer to trust in the party that controls this channel (in our research context, brand trust). A relationship between enjoyment and trust in a communication channel is further supported by Friedrich and colleagues (2019).The flow theory can be used to understand this relationship further, as flow is a deemed a concept conceptually close to enjoyment. Indeed, it is suggested that when people are in the flow state, they are totally engrossed in the task at hand which will make them exclude other thoughts or factors around them, reducing attention to feelings of risk and uncertainty which will ultimately lead to increasing feelings of trust (Csikszentmihalyi & Csikzentmihaly, 1990). Therefore, we hypothesize that:

H5: Customers' enjoyment of the influencer's advert endorsing a brand positively affects their trust in the brand.

3 Materials and Methods

3.1 Data Collection

The 354 participants in this cross-sectional study are university students studying various academic disciplines in a medium-size university in Bahrain. The students received a link to the online questionnaire by their instructors to be completed in class using their digital devices (i.e., smartphones, tablets, and computers). The students were asked to watch videos of social media influencers endorsing different brands and then answer survey questions.

3.2 Measurement

The questionnaire was created by adapting well-cited scales to reflect the variables in the conceptual model. The measurements for Influencer and Brand Trust were adapted from Cyr et al. (2005), Cyr and Trevor-Smith (2004), and Gefen and Straub (2003). The Brand Liking scale was adapted form Guillory and Sundar (2014), while the Ad Enjoyment scale was adapted from Cyr et al. (2009). All of these questions were measured using a five-point Likert scale and adapted to fit the context of this study.

3.3 Data Analysis

As a start, descriptive statistics were run in SPSS 23. To test the proposed model, the partial least square structural equation modelling (PLS-SEM) techniques were implemented using Smart PLS software. This technique is deemed most appropriate for analyzing models with various relationships and constructs in them. Additionally, the existence of both reflective and formative indicators in the model, made it necessary for PLS-SEM analysis techniques to be used (Hair et al., 2016).

4 Results

In this section, the descriptive statistics will be first outlined, followed by reliability and validity analyses for the model's constructs. Due to the existence of both formative and reflective variables in the model, different reliability and validity tests were conducted for variables of each type. An estimation of the overall model using the bootstrapping technique follows, presenting the hypothesis results.

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

This survey was completed by 354 adults between the ages of 18 and 65 years old, however, most of the participants were young adults between the ages of 18–24 years old (72.6%). The percentage of females (57.6%) was slightly higher than that of males (42.4%) in the sample. When it comes to time spent on social media platforms, 39.3% of the participants said they spend more than 3 h a day using various social media platforms, 22.6% said they spend 2–3 h and the rest of the participants said they spend less than 2 h a day on social media. As to participants' favorite social media platform, Instagram came on top (35.6%), followed by WhatsApp (29.1%)

and Snapchat (17.5%). Around 70% of the survey respondents indicated that they trusted social media influencers.

4.2 Reliability and Validity of Measurement Models

In this section, we discuss the reliability and validity of the reflective and formative measures in the conceptual model. Three reflective measurement models (i.e., Influencer Trust, Ad Enjoyment, and Brand Trust) and one formative measurement model (i.e., Brand Liking) were assessed. According to Hair Jr et al. (2016), the difference between reflective and formative measures lies in the fact that the constructs in reflective measures can be interchangeable, whereas formative measures are not (i.e. the variable itself is a combination of the constructs).

Reflective measurement model assessment
Following the recommendations of Hair Jr et al. (2016), the reflective measures in this model were examined in terms of (1) convergent validity (2) composite reliability, and (3) discriminant validity. To examine convergent validity, the outer loadings of the indicators are evaluated to ensure that they are significant, exceeding the threshold of 0.708. The outer loadings of all the model's reflective constructs exceed the threshold as shown in Table 1, suggesting convergent validity. Convergent validity is further confirmed, as the average value extracted (AVE) exceeds the suggested threshold of 0.500 (Table 1). Additionally, composite reliability is confirmed as it is above the suggested threshold of 0.800 for all of the variables (Table 1).

To examine discriminant validity, the cross loadings of the indicators are evaluated. As highlighted in table 2, the outer loadings of each construct's indicators are larger than all of the other construct indicator loadings, thus indicating discriminant validity.

Table 1 Results of reflective measurement models

Latent variables	Indicators	Outer loadings	AVE	Composite reliability	Discriminant validity?
Influencer trust	INF_TRUST1	0.8887	0.7935	0.9202	Yes
	INF_TRUST2	0.9161			
	INF_TRUST3	0.8669			
Ad enjoyment	AD_ENJOY1	0.8969	0.8294	0.9511	Yes
	AD_ENJOY2	0.9197			
	AD_ENJOY3	0.9199			
	AD_ENJOY4	0.9062			
Brand trust	BRAND_TRUST1	0.8866	0.776	0.9202	Yes
	BAND_TRUST2	0.8943			
	BAND_TRUST3	0.8616			

Table 2 Cross loadings of indicators

Indicators	Ad enjoyment	Brand trust	Influencer trust
AD_ENJOY1	**0.8969**	0.4897	0.6244
AD_ENJOY2	**0.9197**	0.4625	0.6446
AD_ENJOY3	**0.9199**	0.4719	0.6609
AD_ENJOY4	**0.9062**	0.4618	0.6347
BRAND_TRUST1	0.4341	**0.8866**	0.512
BAND_TRUST2	0.4906	**0.8943**	0.5238
BAND_TRUST3	0.4446	**0.8616**	0.4898
INF_TRUST2	0.6718	0.5538	**0.9161**
INF_TRUST3	0.58	0.5084	**0.8669**
INF_TRUST1	0.6261	0.4777	**0.8887**

The Fornell-Larcker criterion was additionally used to confirm the discriminant validity. As highlighted in Table 3, the square roots of the AVE for each construct were found to be larger than the correlation coefficients between the construct at hand and all of the other constructs in the study's model, thus confirming the discriminant validity.

Formative measurement model assessment

The formative measures were examined for (1) collinearity and (2) significance of the outer weights of the indicators according to the recommendations by Hair Jr et al. (2016). To detect any collinearity issues, the variance inflation factor (VIF) values were measured. As depicted in Table 4, the highest VIF of the formative indicators is 2.9468 which is well below the suggested threshold of 5. Therefore, collinearity is not an issue in the formative constructs and is not expected to negatively affect the estimation of the model.

Table 3 Fornell-larcker criterion

Construct	Ad enjoyment	Brand trust	Influencer trust
Ad enjoyment	**0.9107**		
Brand trust	0.5177	**0.8809**	
Influencer trust	0.7041	0.5774	**0.8908**

Table 4 Variance inflation factor (VIF)

Construct	Indicators	VIF
Brand liking	BRAND_LIK1	2.2603
	BRAND_LIK2	2.9468
	BRAND_LIK3	2.2348
	BRAND_LIK4	2.7976
	BRAND_LIK5	2.699

Table 5 Significance of outer weights

Indicators	t-value	p-value
BRAND_LIK1	6.2542	0
BRAND_LIK2	0.4826	0.6296
BRAND_LIK3	7.6808	0
BRAND_LIK4	3.3593	0.0008
BRAND_LIK5	3.8514	0.0001

As shown in Table 5, the outer weights' p-values of all but one of the indicators are significant at the 1% level. The remaining indicator (i.e., BRAND_LIK2) is insignificant, however, since its outer loading is significant, it will be kept in the model.

4.3 Hypothesis Testing

The first step of testing the model is to examine each set of independent variables separately in each relationship in the structural model for collinearity issues. As shown in Table 6, all of the VIF values are all below 5. Therefore, collinearity is not deemed an issue in this structural model.

The significance of each hypothesized relationship in the model is then assessed using bootstrapping techniques. All of the hypothesized relationships in the model are significant at the 1% level, except the relationship between ad enjoyment and brand trust, which is insignificant as shown in Table 7.

Moreover, the explanatory power of the independent variables (R2) ranges from approximately 36% to 58% (Table 8), with brand trust being the most explained by its predictor variables (57.79%), followed by ad enjoyment (49.58%) and brand liking (36.19%). The R square value for ad enjoyment is especially interesting, as this construct is only predicted by one variable (i.e., influencer trust) in the study's model.

Finally, when running post-hoc mediation analysis it was found that brand liking partially mediates the relationship between influencer trust and brand trust.

Table 6 Collinearity assessment of the model

Construct	Ad enjoyment	Brand like	Brand trust
Ad enjoyment			2.2051
Brand liking			1.7423
Influencer trust	1	1	2.1973

Table 7 Findings from partial least-squares structural equation modeling

H#	Hypotheses	p-values	Accepted or rejected?
1	Influencer trust positively affects customers' brand trust	0	Accepted
2	Influencer trust positively affects customers' brand liking	0	Accepted
3	Influencer trust positively affects customers' ad enjoyment	0	Accepted
4	Brand liking positively affects customers' brand trust	0	Accepted
5	Ad enjoyment positively affects customers' brand trust	0.9928	Rejected

Table 8 R^2 results

Construct level	R^2
Ad enjoyment	0.4958
Brand liking	0.3619
Brand trust	0.5779

5 Discussion

This study contributes to the literature by empirically investigating social media influencer marketing and its impact on customer perceptions of the brand. It specifically sheds light on the role of trust transfer between SMIs and the brand they are endorsing, in addition to mediators of this transfer. Indeed, influencer trust is still a nascent research area and the papers investigating its nuances are generally limited (Kim & Kim, 2021). However, investigating the customers' trust in social media influencers is of increasing importance, as consumers are getting more and more skeptical of this marketing method with time (Mannheim, 2021; Watson, 2019). Therefore, the researchers, first, aimed to uncover if social media influencers are still trusted by consumers. Indeed, based on our descriptive statistics, it turns out that 70% of the survey respondents trusted social media influencers. Additionally, we aimed to find out if this trust transfers to trust in the brands endorsed by the influencers, and if brand liking and ad enjoyment mediate this relationship.

In our model, we hypothesized a positive relationship between the customers' trust in a social media influencer and their trust in the brand that they are promoting and found significant support for this relationship (H1). This is consistent with the propositions of the trust transfer theory, which suggests that an individual could trust a party if they are associated with another party that they already have trust in Stewart (Smith, 2004; Zhao et al., 2019; 2003). The consumers trust in an influencer has also been found to lead to brand liking (H2), which consistent with both the signaling theory (Chen et al., 2019) and the social learning theory (Bandura, 1971; Glucksman, 2017). These two findings reflect that despite some consumers' skepticism toward social media influencers, influencers do still influence their followers and affect their perceptions toward brands, whether in terms of trust or liking.

An interesting finding from this paper is the impact of the influencer's trust on ad enjoyment (H3). Indeed, our results indicate that almost half of the ad enjoyment sentiments in the study's sample can be explained by influencer trust. This is an important finding, because trust is usually linked in research to customers' behaviors and intentions and very rarely to their affective responses. Therefore, for influencer trust to have this high explanatory value to ad enjoyment is a novel finding. It is important to bear in mind, however, that only video adverts were shown to the respondents in this study, so customers' enjoyment of other ad formats could be different.

Through our results, it was found that brand liking is significantly connected to brand trust (H4). This is the first study that links these two constructs in the field of influencer marketing, although significant relationships between salesperson liking and trust was found in prior research (Doney & Cannon, 1997; Nicholson et al., 2001). Finally, no significant relationship was found between ad enjoyment and brand trust (H5). This means that the ad itself, even if very enjoyable, does not necessary send signals of brand trust to the consumers.

The findings from this research highlight that social media influencer marketing can still be regarded as an effective tool in a company's digital strategy. However, it is necessary that marketers pick influencers that are trustworthy to their audiences in order for such marketing efforts to succeed. Our results are especially useful for social media influencers, as they highlight the importance of nurturing and growing a trusting relationship between them and their audience. If they do not achieve such relationship, they then will not be able transfer trust to the brands they are promoting, whether they their own or other companies' brands.

For future research, it would be interesting to find out, through a longitudinal study, if trust in the influencer transfers to short-term or long-term trust in the brand and what affects the persistence of this trust. Another interesting future research subject would be about the effect of cancel culture on trust in influencers and brands.

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